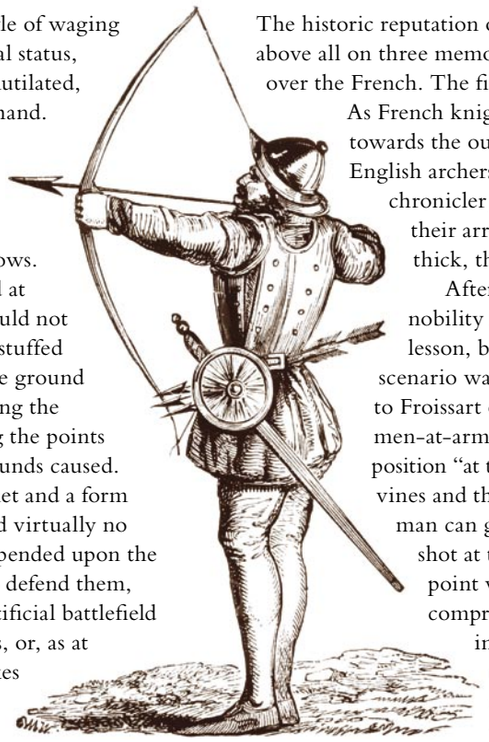
> “THE ENGLISH ARCHERS ISSUED FROM BEHIND THEIR STOCKADE, THREW AWAY THEIR BOWS … THEN TOOK THEIR SWORDS … AND OTHER WEAPONS, AND KILLED THESE FRENCHMEN WITHOUT MERCY.”
>
> FRENCH CHRONICLER **JEHAN DE WAVRIN**, DESCRIBING THE BATTLE OF AGINCOURT

both for their cowardly style of waging war and for their low social status, they would probably be mutilated, tortured, or killed out of hand.

IN BATTLE

In preparing for battle, a bowman would equip himself with about 60 arrows. So these could be accessed at maximum speed, they would not be carried in a quiver but stuffed in his belt or stuck into the ground at his feet – the latter having the added advantage of soiling the points and thus infecting any wounds caused. Some archers wore a helmet and a form of mail coat, but many had virtually no body protection. They depended upon the armoured men-at-arms to defend them, as well as on natural or artificial battlefield obstacles – hedges, ditches, or, as at Agincourt, sharpened stakes set point upward in the ground between them and the enemy horsemen. As well as shooting arrows, the archers fought as light infantry. For this purpose they were armed with daggers, axes, and lead “mauls” (hammers or mallets). When their arrows had reduced charging cavalry to a chaos of thrashing fallen horses and half-stunned, unhorsed knights, the archers would rush forward to slaughter the enemy with their edged weapons – as well as to retrieve arrows that could be reused, since ammunition could quickly be exhausted.



Armoured bowman
This English longbowman from the end of the 15th century wears light armour and a helmet and carries a sword and buckler. Archers from the golden age of Crécy and Agincourt would not have been so well armed.

The historic reputation of the longbowmen rests above all on three memorable English victories over the French. The first was at Crécy in 1346. As French knights charged impetuously towards the outnumbered English, the English archers, in the words of French chronicler Jean Froissart, “let fly their arrows so wholly and so thick, that it seemed snow”.

After this débacle the French nobility might have learned their lesson, but at Poitiers in 1356 the scenario was repeated. According to Froissart once more, the English men-at-arms and archers were in a position “at the end of a hedge among vines and thorn bushes, where no man can go nor ride”. The archers shot at the French knights at a point where their charge was compressed into a narrow gap in the hedge, concentrating their fire on the horses rather than the riders, whose armour was hard to penetrate. Fallen horses caused chaos and an English counterattack won the day after fierce hand-to-hand fighting in which the archers’ axes and daggers saw plentiful use. Finally at the Battle of Agincourt in 1415 an English force of around 6,000 men, probably including some 5,000 archers, defeated a French army as much as four times its size.

LONGBOWMEN ON THE BATTLEFIELD

The English deployed archers defensively, relying on their enemies to attack first. How exactly the archers were positioned is a matter of dispute between historians, and may well have varied considerably according to the terrain and the number of troops on each side. On some occasions they were massed on the flanks of the army, or on the flanks of each “battle” into which the army was subdivided. But at Agincourt they were probably deployed in front of or in between the men-at-arms, protected against the enemy’s cavalry charge by sharpened stakes laid out in a chequerboard pattern. The archers would generally be by far the most numerous element of the English army. Their shower of arrows was intended to halt and disorganize the advancing enemy. Men-at-arms fighting on foot and the archers themselves would then rush forward to finish them off.

DECLINE OF THE LONGBOWMAN

The English archers were by no means universally victorious, however. Indeed, after Agincourt they were almost always on the losing side, especially when the French began to make effective use of cannon in the closing stages of the Hundred Years’ War. Whether the longbow was rendered obsolete by the rise of gunpowder weapons is not clear. Its virtual disappearance from the battlefield in the 16th century certainly coincided with the introduction of the arquebus and the musket. But it would be another 300 years before any firearm could match the longbow’s performance, firing 12 times a minute and consistently hitting a target 200m (218 yards) distant.

Perhaps the most convincing explanation of the military decline of the longbow lies in the disappearance of the extensive pool of skilled archers on which it depended, itself partly caused by a long period during which England was relatively at peace. It was no longer possible to employs massed bows because there were simply not enough people capable of shooting them.



Longbow and arrows
The greatest archaeological hoard of English longbows and arrows was found aboard the *Mary Rose*, the Tudor warship that sank in 1545 and was raised from the seabed in 1982. The bows ranged between 1.87m and 2.11m (6ft 1in and 6ft 10in) in length.